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by Riteliso

Summary

Catra's having difficulties getting used to life in Brightmoon. Adora proposes they spar, one of the only ways they were able to relax in the Horde. It helps a lot- the untwisted duo return to their room, less nervous and more loving, but as adversarial as always.

The ceiling almost felt as if it were curving, twisting, and *twirling* as Adora anxiously stared into it. She knew Catra was awake, but Catra was trying to stay very *still.* Glimmer had blown up on Catra yesterday- it was far from undeserved, but the fog of dread that lingered in the room had a sort of *bitter* taste. Adora's fears of Catra running away had been nearly *constant* this last week- Catra wasn't able to adapt to Brightmoon very easily, and Brightmoon refused to carry double standards in her favour.

With King Micah and Glimmer leading the kingdom together, Catra had already been afforded an amount of lenience that would be more than enough for anyone *besides* Catra. Catra, technically speaking, was serving a jail sentence- but it was even more transparently performative than any of the previous honoured guests the kingdom had called prisoners.

She was free to come and go as she pleased. All that was asked of her is that she not sneak around- just to be considerate enough to let people know where she was going and when. Glimmer found it very difficult to believe that these rules were difficult to follow, even though Adora had all but *assured* her Catra wouldn't be able to comply.

Sometimes Adora just tried to keep Catra *away* from Glimmer. It stressed her and Bow *out* too much. Glimmer had also been really needling Adora for not preventing Catra's sneaking around because 'you two are practically attached at the side, so you know when she does it.'

Adora didn't know how to broach the subject- It isn't exactly *easy* to warn your friend that they're unintentionally mirroring the abusive guardian you watched *die* . Adora viewed Catra's frustration in a much more sympathetic light than she had in a long, *long* time. This was how they grew up.

Catra was a prisoner, but since Adora slept and ate with her, she felt like a prisoner too- even in the insane luxury that comes with the Brightmoon prison 'system.' They were prisoners, but Catra's

happy to sneak out- and whenever they get caught where they're not supposed to be, or doing what they're not supposed to do, Catra gets chewed out and Adora gets told she needs to be keeping her in line better.

Adora's ear twitched as she heard Catra sniffle. Yesterday's blowup hadn't been because of anything like sneaking around- it was about how Catra *acted* . About how Catra *talked* . About how Catra didn't like being touched, but seemed so quick to push and *shove* . Adora remembered the difficulties of socially adjusting to Brightmoon- the very low constitution for bleaker humour was a speed-bump that Adora tripped over as well. But instead of catching her footing, Catra often seemed to land flat on her face.

Yesterday, the four of them had been in the whispering woods. Catra would often pause while walking; getting fully distracted- The wildlife that surrounded them both frightened and fascinated her. Bow remarked on it being 'cute' one too many times and Catra made a promise along the lines of 'slicing bow into ribbons and using them to tie knots around the flowers at his closed-casket funeral.' Adora laughed- she'd missed how *absurd* Catra's threats would be at the *simplest* of slights. Glimmer did *not* laugh. Glimmer glared at Adora, walked up to Catra, and poked her in the centre of the chest while chewing her out for her 'nasty behaviour.'

Catra didn't escalate, for which Adora was *very* thankful- and admittedly *surprised* . They split into two groups- Bow and Glimmer continued their nature walk, and Catra and Adora had a very quiet walk home.

Following that, the evening in that the two had was as lovely and simple as things *always* were when it was just the two of them. The two laughed and chatted and snacked- but when Catra was in her lap and Adora placed a kiss on the top of her head, Catra shrunk away a bit. Last night had been the first night in a long time that they hadn't cuddled.

And now Catra felt like a *bomb* at Adora's feet. Like a pressure had been building up for over a month now, and every jab might finally tear the hole that has her exploding completely, or propels her straight away like a rocket.

Adora attempts to break the silence.

"Did we ever do anything to relax?"

Catra stays still for a moment before giving up on pretending to be asleep. "There's not much *relaxing* to do in the Fright Zone besides hitting people."

Adora thinks for a second, before offering a ridiculously direct solution. "Well, we haven't *sparred* in a while."

Catra's ears twitch and she rolls over and onto her elbow so that her eyes meet with Adora's.

"And I mean- people are worried about all the Hordak clones, so- I don't think they'd *stop* us from training."

"So you're saying you *want* me to hit you?" Catra's eyes thin as she smugly grins.

Adora rolled her eyes. "I *want* you to *relax.* And nobody'll be there to gang up on you, either, so- it should be fun. Just the two of us."

Catra laughs. Her face is beaming as the blanket falls away and Adora struggles not to make eye contact with her chest. Catra stopped wearing tops to sleep once she'd finally escaped the Fright Zone- Adora tried it once but felt *far* too exposed. Catra immediately begins getting dressed.

Adora slowly got up, still unable to tear her eyes from a happy Catra. She'd noticed that the phrase 'just the two of us' very reliably got Catra excited, but because of that, Adora tried her best not to overuse it. She often found herself a bit paralyzed by self-consciousness when it came to avoiding being manipulative to Catra. It was a sort of multi-layered fear that she did her best to

quell by remembering that Catra *loved* her. She didn't *need* to be manipulative. Catra wanted her to be *happy* .

Those reassurances very rarely *helped* . She was able to believe that Catra loved her, usually- and when she could fully feel that in her heart it came with an inexhaustible energy and happiness that made her feel like she was going to *pop* . But the whole part about Catra wanting her to be happy often seemed- demonstrably *wrong* . If Catra loved her, Catra had *always* loved her. And even when Catra loved her, Catra was prepared to destroy everyone and everything she loved with a perverse glee at seeing how it'd make Adora suffer.

"... Are you going to get dressed or are you staying in undies all day?" Catra questioned, snapping Adora back to her senses.

"Sorry, I- I was just lost in thought a bit."

Catra's smile faded. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah." Adora could tell that wasn't a convincing answer. "Just worried I guess."

"Worried about *me?* " Catra accused, unimpressed.

"No! I mean, worried about- I just really enjoy having you in my life again. I'm- worried about *me* . It's just that- you're involved. Does any of that make sense?" Adora stumbled through her explanation.

Catra stood for a moment, judging the response. "At least you're *honest* . Anyway, I'll be *fine.* I'm not going to run away. I don't have anywhere to run *to.* "

Adora had an exceptionally difficult time believing that would stop her, but all the same took the time to finally pull on her clothes and find her telescopic staves.

As the pair finally set out, Catra was confused.

“Why are we walking this way? I thought we were gonna spar outside.”

“We are! I’m just gonna tell Glimmer.”

Catra cocked an eyebrow. “Are you *really* sure that’s a good idea? Isn’t she gonna get all huffy and elitist about you ‘supporting my violent tendencies’ and hand you a book on parenting or something?”

Adora couldn’t help but chuckle. “No- She has a hard time understanding things, I know- but she’s not going to be *weird* about it.” That was an outright lie, but she was trusting Glimmer to *pretend* not to be judgemental.

When she knocked on Glimmer’s door there was no response. She waited a while, looked at Catra, then knocked again.

The door eventually opened, revealing a Glimmer with a *severe* case of bedhead. Catra stifled a laugh, to which Glimmer seemingly paid no mind.

“What?” She questioned, getting straight to the point.

“Oh, uh, me and Catra were just going out. Thought we’d tell you.”

“You horde types are always up so early-”

“It’s 11am.” Catra says, before Adora elbows her.

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “What are you two going out to *do?* ”

“Just to spar.” Adora responds, wearing a big fake smile, trying to signal as clearly as she can not to make a scene.

Glimmer narrows her eyes at the two, looking at them like they were crazy. “ *Right.* Are we *sure* that’s a good idea?”

Catra’s tail flicks back and forth.

“Glimmer, you and your dad have said before- just because Horde Prime was defeated doesn’t mean we can relax. There’s a practically infinite amount of Horde clones out there, all of which were raised on the idea that conquering the lands is their very reason to live. We shouldn’t be getting out of practice, right? And Catra is my most practiced sparring partner!”

Glimmer glares at Adora, thoroughly unconvinced. “... *Sure* . Look, I don’t have time for this. Just be careful.” She shoots Catra a look as she closes the door.

Once the door is shut Catra grumbles. “Good morning to you, too, Sparkles.”

Adora breathes a sigh of relief.

“And did she just say ‘I don’t have time for this’ and then go back to sleep?”

Adora snorts. “Princesses, right?”

Catra softly smiles. Being together was the only part of the familiarity from the Fright Zone that felt *calming* .

On their way out of the door, they see Bow on his way in.

“Oh! Hey, you two!” His grin is plastered along his face, same as it always is. “Where are you off to?”

Catra keeps walking, happy to blow past him without even speaking, but Adora grabs her hand to stop her, much to Catra’s chagrin.

“We’re off to spar.” Adora states plainly.

Bow’s clearly a bit surprised, but he lets it subside quickly. “Okay, have fun! Just try not to get carried away.”

There’s a pause as Catra’s expression fades from frustration all the way down to understanding. “Uh, about yesterday- Sorry.”

Bow smiles.

Catra bristles a bit. "It was a joke, but since I've fought you all so many times, y'know- I should probably be more careful. Probably." Her eyes dart around.

"Catra, it's fine, really. The same sort of stuff happened with Adora early on," he reassures.

Catra smiles up at Adora. "Really? Now that *is* interesting. Any examples?"

Adora goes red. "I don't think we-"

"One time a bird woke us up early and Adora told me to 'find it and crush its head between my palms." Bow chuckles.

"Ha! And here she made it sound like her transition to staying here was ' *effortless* ."

Adora begins shuffling her and Catra forward while stumbling through a clumsy goodbye to Bow. Catra continues chuckling until they're out of earshot.

"Those two are dating or something, right? Poor guy." She smiles.

"**Catra-** " Adora starts. "I know you and Glimmer don't get along, but c'mon. Don't be mean like *that.* "

" *What?* I'm being *nice* to *Bow.* " She smugly asserts her point, finally walking forward without being pushed ahead.

"Glimmer's a really great friend- she's just not easy to get to know. Sometimes she pushes people away."

Catra's tail flicks, clearly irritated. "Mm."

Adora thinks for a second. "Wait, did I say something?"

Catra's eyes look back, scanning the honesty in Adora's ignorance. She shrugs. "Nah, nevermind."

Adora wants to dig deeper, but Catra's tail has stopped flicking, so she delicately decides not to.

The clearing they reach is picturesque- A few scattered patches of dirt from where campers have lit their fires next to a tall cliff face that blocks off escape. It reminds Adora of one of the horde's training layouts.

Catra walks in, absently examining seemingly insignificant details as her tail seems to occasionally twitch. She looks back at Adora, seemingly satisfied with the location.

"I can work with this. Pass me a staff." She confidently closes her eyes.

Adora's slightly worried by Catra's immediate sense of focus. "Sure- here." Hesitantly, she tosses Catra a staff.

Catra fumbles with it for a second, before properly catching and telescoping it. It seems almost unfamiliar in her hands. Adora guesses it's been quite a while since she used one.

Reassured, Adora prepares. Stretches, deep breaths, and a bit of jogging in place.

"Now, Catra, just because we're dating, that doesn't mean I'll take it easy on you, okay?" Adora teases.

"Are we dating? Did we make that official?" Catra questions offhandedly.

The colour drains from Adora's face for a moment. "I- Sorry, I thought-"

Her already derailed train of thought explodes as Catra rushes at her before she's even unfurled her staff. She barely manages to block in time for the loud ***KLAK*** to shatter the air. One strike and Adora already feels exhausted- just not in the way she was *picturing* .

Catra giggles as she swipes off the top of her staff, swinging for Adora's side. Adora manages to block as she steps back, but as Catra's repeated swings shake Adora's bones all the way through the staff. It's not long before Catra uses her foot to kick Adora backward, where she trips over an overgrown root and lands flat on her back.

"Really!? That's messed up, even for *you.* " Adora says, her whole world spinning as she stares up at a smug feline grin.

Catra extends her hand. "Warmups don't count, so I get to do whatever I *want* during them."

Adora grasps Catra's hand and she gets pulled to her feet. "Fine. You can't *win* a warmup, anyway."

"Oh, Adora. Of *course* there's no winning a warmup. Which is why it doesn't matter at all that you *lost* ." Catra brings Adora in *close.*

Adora smiles through a thick pout. "Quit looking at me like that, you jerk." She manages a chuckle, but nonetheless she *does* feel a little stung. It was a little too familiar- Catra keeping her distracted so that she can't think straight.

"Oh, don't be such a *baby* , Adora." Catra laughs. "That was the *first round.* Come on, I'll play nice this time." She cracks her back as she leads Adora back to the middle of the clearing.

Adora tries to focus but is finding it difficult. Not only the needling, but the fact that she really *would* like to know if she and Catra are dating. Isn't that important? Does Catra know? Isn't it impossible for Catra to know if *she* doesn't know?

Catra's face fades into mild annoyance as Adora keeps her waiting. Her tail flicks to and fro as she continues to stay on guard. Her eyes scan Adora, piercing through her. It feels almost cold.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Adora, *what?* "

Adora immediately drops her guard and speaks much faster than she means to. "You didn't actually answer if we were dating or not. I'd like to know. Do you think we're dating?"

Catra scoffs, seeming offended. Adora doesn't think that's a very fair response, but Catra steels herself and replies. "If you can knock me down, we'll date. Deal?"

Adora goes great lengths to attempt and hide her glee. Knocking Catra down is much more difficult than just disarming her, but Adora's done it *plenty* of times before. *"Deal."*

Adora rushes at Catra, who dives over her and flips before jabbing Adora in the back. The pain pangs into Adora's head before she swings back to counterattack, but connects with Catra's staff, which almost bends from the force.

As they exchange blows it feels notably awkward- while Adora's used to using a staff; Catra's playing even more evasive than usual. She clearly finds it difficult to find opportunities to strike. She tries to sweep Adora's legs with her staff but just ends up roughly bludgeoning Adora's shin, which almost immediately begins to bruise.

Adora grits her teeth and gets close enough to shove Catra back. Catra goes flying back, and trips backward over the very same root- but her claws dig into the tree, managing to keep her from falling down completely. She hops back up, panting a bit.

"What the hell! Don't you *want* to date?" Adora complains.

"Don't *you? You* still haven't knocked me down." Catra flips the question.

Catra's dry tone gets under Adora's skin. Adora throws down her staff and approaches Catra- Catra's response is *curious* , to say the least.

Catra excitedly tosses her staff to the side and melts into the brush, her chittering laughter being the only thing Adora can

track.

“Get back here! Stay in the clearing!” Adora commands, huffing as she scans the foliage for a pair of mismatched eyes. She spots them, but doesn’t let her eyes lock onto them, instead feigning ignorance.

Catra pounces, laughing, but yelps in surprise as Adora catches her by her wrists. Adora smiles at Catra as she struggles in her grasp. Catra looks as determined as ever, but simply can’t match Adora’s strength.

“Your eyes are *way* too pretty to miss.” Adora teases.

Catra makes a cartoonish fake vomit noise. “Gee, *thanks,* ” she remarks, scanning her surroundings. “So, back touching the ground- we’re counting *that* , right? Like- *that’s* knocked down?”

“Yes, so you’re *not* allowed to flip me over you right now.” Adora glares down.

Catra smiles, before shrugging. “Just making sure, because this felt *mean* in comparison.”

She kicks Adora’s bruised shin, sending a jolt through her body as the pain surges through her core. Catra hops up enough to plant her feet on Adora’s thighs, and then flips backward, wrenching her wrists from Adora’s loosened grasp.

Adora feels a very intense anger well up in her core- but as she looks up and sees Catra gleefully laughing in the centre of the clearing it melts away. As she breathes, peace washes over her, watching Catra just- enjoying herself. Adora smiles, because with peace that brings-

“For the honour of Greyskull-” she gently speaks to herself, hoping her sparring partner continues to laugh long enough that she won’t notice.

By the time Adora *does* jump out, Catra yells and jumps back, her claws digging into the face of the cliff.

"What the hell!? You can't use She-ra to win a sparring bet! That isn't fair!" Catra whines as Adora cracks her knuckles.

"You've fought She-ra more than anyone else. You're a big girl, you can handle her." Adora proudly says as her kitty pouts.

Catra, grumpy, tries to jump over She-ra but doesn't quite make it. With She-ra's added height Adora easily grabs Catra by the ankles as she yelps, before swinging her down onto the soft grass and jumping on top of her to pin her.

A dizzied Catra shakes her head. Conflicted feelings wash over her face. The only thing her emotions seem to agree on is making her as red as possible. Eventually she manages to meet Adora's gaze.

The two stare at each-other. Adora wishes this could last forever. Catra wishes it would *end* already.

Catra growls, surprising Adora.

"Will you hurry up and *kiss* me already!? *God!* " Her tail is flailing, tapping Adora's legs.

Adora only hesitates for a moment before diving in. Their lips dance until Catra gets impatient and sticks her rough tongue into Adora's mouth. Adora clumsily reciprocates, but it's very clear these two are thoroughly inexperienced when it comes to kissing.

This was only their second time kissing each-other- there were plenty of forehead and cheek kisses since Catra came to Brightmoon, but the only time their lips had touched was after Catra got a glass of water and thought Adora was asleep. Considering what a bad actor Adora was, she thought it was a miracle that Catra didn't notice.

Once the kiss breaks, Adora continues scanning Catra's face. Catra doesn't look- *happy* . She looks frustrated. Nervous. All the same,

Catra says it.

“I love you.”

The joy surging through Adora’s body makes it difficult to say *anything.* But with tears filling her eyes, her wavering voice echoes Catra’s.

“I love you, too.”

Catra’s bottom lip quivers as Adora sniffles and begins to cry. She-ra fades away as she’s replaced by a smaller, frailer, and more *scared* girl. But Catra doesn’t feel any different. She knows better. Even if Adora wasn’t She-ra, she’d still be on her back under her. No matter what.

“Can I hold you?” Adora chokes out in a shaky voice.

Instead of responding Catra wraps her arms around Adora tightly. Initially her claws are cautious, unwilling to dig in. But the restraint fades away as Catra feels Adora’s arms around her. Heaving breaths heat Adora’s neck as the two squeeze each-other. “I’m scared,” Catra whispers. She’s practically *convulsing*. “It- Everyone- They all *leave.*” She squeaks.

“I’m sorry, Catra. I’m so, so sorry.” Adora shakes while she tries her best to remain composed- for Catra’s sake. “I- I want to make it up to you more than anything. I don’t- I just need to know *how.* ”

Catra doesn’t answer. In fact, Catra remains wordless until they head *back* . Only scattered sniffles and chokes as the tears threaten to return. Adora’s nerves are wracked, hoping that she’ll be alright. Hoping that she hasn’t upset her.

Just before they’re out of the woods- only a handful of leaves before they enter into the view of the castle, Catra stops Adora. She gently and sweetly kisses her, and then rests her head on her chest. Adora gently strokes her back, loosely holding her.

Adora wants Catra to be happy here, but if she's not, Adora would be- *fine* just *visiting* the castle, rather than living there full time. Admittedly, though, she'd really prefer *not* to move.

Seemingly, neither would Catra, because they stand there with Catra's head on her chest until Catra hears someone coming.

She grabs Adora by the hand and begins by leading her to the door- before slowing her pace so that it's actually clear that they're *casually* holding hands. As they walk through the halls hand in hand it feels like all eyes are on them- they're not *kids* anymore, but the people of Brightmoon tend to treat *every* 'first' of *every* kind as a big deal, even if it's just the first time they've *seen* it.

Adora receives half a dozen nods of approval on their way to their room. Just before the doors open, Catra offhandedly remarks-

"How do you hold your weapons so tight when your hands are so sweaty?" She pulls Adora into their room. Her tail flops back and forth, clearly embarrassed.

Adora weakly chuckles. "Fighting doesn't make me nearly as nervous, I guess."

Catra sighs. "I don't know what to do with myself here. At least this *room* feels safe. That's better than we had at the Fright Zone." She collapses backward onto her bed. "... We need a bigger mattress. I'm tired of being either scrunched to cuddle together or sleeping at your feet. *I'd like more options.* " She nervously drums her fingers.

Adora sits down next to Catra's legs. She looks around the room. "Catra- when I left you, I rationalized it in a way that I really regret now."

Catra doesn't react.

"In my head I sort of made it feel like *you* left *me* when you refused to leave the horde. I think the fact you knew more about

their scumminess than I did made that easier- I don't know. I just- I regret it."

She doesn't even flinch.

"I should have owned up to it. I didn't really think about how you felt until after the portal. You were willing to destroy the whole world- it made me realize how much-"

"Do we *have* to talk about this?" Catra grumbles.

"I thought you wanted to." Adora replies meekly.

Catra stays quiet for a bit. She sighs, and mumbles, and then eventually *speaks*. "I never really felt like I *owned* anything. *Ever*. As a kid all we had were our clothes- even *then,* just *barely.* But *you* made friends. Friends *I* didn't *have*. Friends that didn't even *like* me. I felt like the only thing I could ever hope to have was *you.* And it always felt like you were slowly slipping away. It felt like there was always going to be some higher calling or better friend that would get you in the end… And then that feeling was *right.* So I had *nothing*. I was *above* your old friends. The new 'friends' I made couldn't make me happy. So- I pulled that lever because I had *nothing.* There wasn't a better future I could imagine at the time than destroying everything that had ever been or would be."

Adora swallows. Catra is smiling blankly.

"And then I got to see you again- I thought it was heaven. I kept saying things were perfect because they really *felt* that way. And even once I realized we were all going to be turned into nothingness- I got to go knowing *you'd* be going, *too* . Together again, in the one way I could control."

Adora is very uncertain what to say. "So- what changed?"

"Hm?"

“On Horde Prime’s ship you sacrificed yourself for me. You were willing to go down to *save* me, instead of taking me with you. What changed?”

Catra’s tail gently wraps around Adora’s wrist. “Everything just hurt a little less. I was backed into a corner where my two options were ‘do nothing, get pronounced useless, and die,’ or ‘save the girl you love.’ I don’t understand why you act like it was such an impressive feat of will.”

Adora thinks for a moment as Catra’s tail squeezes her. “Well- I’m not sure I believe that. I think you *did* change. I’m trying to pin down *when.* ”

Catra’s tail squeezes Adora’s wrist *harder* . “Maybe.” She sighs through her nose. “Maybe when I was finally *alone* . The only person left in my life was Hordak and I finally had the power over *him* , instead of the other way around. I wasn’t happy, though. I was more *miserable* than ever. Everyone left me and most of them were *right* to.”

Adora flinches at the phrasing. “I’m sorry.”

Catra’s tail releases her wrist. “You didn’t really do anything wrong. You were right to leave the Fright Zone. You were right to leave the Horde.”

“You don’t need to say that. I *know* you don’t believe I didn’t do anything wrong.” Adora shakes her head slightly.

“I mean, you *were* right to leave the Horde. *And* the Fright Zone.” Catra is radiating an unusual kind of apathy.

“Yeah, but, I hurt you. Even if it was the right thing to do, I’m sorry.”

“... I guess.”

Adora shifts her weight around. “I really want to make it up to you.”

Somehow it feels like the silence is echoing through the room.

"Adora, I want that too. But there's no way to say this next part without being shitty- I don't know if that's *possible* . You ruined my life to save the world. It was the right thing to do- I just don't know if it could ever be made up to me."

Adora's mind is racing. So is her heart. She doesn't know how to fix this. She feels a nausea that settles in her gut like a rock- but not one smoothed by a river. It's jagged and *rough* . It's hard for her to breathe.

She feels a kiss on her cheek. "Adora, it's fine."

"It's *not* fine. I-"

"It *is* fine!" Catra interrupts. "You don't need to do *every single impossible thing.* Whether you can make it up to me or not- whether I ever recover from it- it doesn't change that I *love* you. I love you here and now. I've hurt you, and you've hurt me. I'm just- not as good at letting stuff go. I don't *know* how you do it."

Adora shudders, some half-and-half cry-laugh escaping her lips.

" *Don't* get all sappy on me." Catra places her hand on Adora's and squeezes.

Adora nods happily, but she's very visibly scattered. Catra seems regretful for allowing this talk to happen in the first place.

" *Alright,* first night as a couple. Are we going to have a nice dinner or something?" Catra attempts to break the mood and change the subject.

"I love you," Adora manages. "I'm so lucky to have you."

Catra cocks her eyebrows. "I love you too, but I'm kind of a nightmare. Like, *objectively* speaking."

Adora shakes her head, to which Catra seems thoroughly unconvinced.

"I'm pretty sure there needs to be a lot *wrong* with you to love me. I mean, *I'm* lucky to have *you,* but I don't want to be the kind of stupid couple that says that stuff back and forth. That's why Lonnie broke up with Kyle."

Adora sniffles. "Noted."

"Now quit crying, it's annoying and I don't know how to fix it." Catra says, cartoonishly wincing and clenching her teeth.

Catra always knew how to make Adora laugh. Regardless of the substance of her jokes, there was always some element of absurd brutality or hubris that soaked every single word. It was one of the many reasons she loved her.

"Alright, are we gonna have a nice dinner, or *what?* " Catra urges impatiently. It's becoming a bit transparent that she's just hungry.

"Well, what do you want?" Adora asks, but she already knows the answer.

"Bread and meat." Catra replies plainly.

Adora rolls her eyes, staring at Catra until she gives an actual answer.

Catra grumbles. "What kind of kingdom is completely devoid of *meat?* I'd even take fish at this point! I've never even tried fish, and I *hate* the sea! I'm desperate!"

"Well, I can't fix that, so what do you want instead?" Adora pushes.

"... The weird sweet bread they have and the soup made from all the foraged stuff." She pouts.

"Maybe also a salad?" Adora offers.

"Got a damn comedian in the house," Catra mumbles while she sulks.

Adora writes down their order, sends it, and pulls the service bell. "How did you end up getting so obsessed with meat in the Fright Zone, anyway? They never let us have any."

"What do you mean? As a kid I stole, and then as a teen I was second in command and got to eat pretty much all the meat there even *was* in the fright zone."

"I mean, I get *that,* but there really isn't much meat eating going on on Etheria at *all* ." Adora said, still not entirely sure of Catra's explanation.

"Yeah, because there's not that many feline or lizard people around compared to, like, everyone else. Look at my teeth! What do you think I evolved to hunt, *fruit?* "

The dental inspection is interrupted by a knock at the door. Adora graciously thanks the server as she brings the tray inside, laying it on the floor so that the two can share their meal.

For all her complaints, Catra doesn't waste time. She's drinking soup straight out of her bowl while it's still steaming. Adora's only slightly more cautious- soaking the bread in the soup before taking bites that are far too big. It's not exactly a *romantic* dinner- Catra's only breaks from slurping her soup seem to be to *breathe* . She only slows down once there's only bread left, and even then, she speaks with her mouth full.

"I *do* love the soup here. I just wish there was anything I could *bite* that tasted at least a *little* like meat." Her teeth tear away another chomp of bread.

Adora blushes at her invasive memories of the many times Catra has bitten her over the years. When they were really little Adora's forearm would be polka-dotted with little marks from Catra's teeth- though most didn't break the skin. As they got older Catra bit less, but when she bit, she'd bite much *harder.*

“Whatcha starin’ into space about?” Catra questions; mouth still full.

“Uh- just memories and stuff. Y’know?” Adora squirms a bit as she dodges the question.

Catra swallows. “Mhm. What about?” Catra’s not the type to let Adora off the hook, especially not without a fight.

“I mean- you were talking about biting. Just-”

Adora is interrupted by Catra’s derisive laughter. “ *Adora!* Have some *class,* we *just* started dating!”

“Shut *up!* I was thinking about when we were kids. You’d bite me all the time.” Adora anxiously tries to continue eating.

“Yeah, you’d ask me to.” Catra says it so dryly that Adora *nearly* believes her.

“... That’s not funny.” Adora blushes, taking another bite.

“I mean, it kind of *is.* ” Catra asserts. “Sometimes you liked it, though. I used to do it to stop you from crying.”

“That’s not how that works- you just made me cry from something *else.* ”

“Yeah, that’s what you said back then, too.” Catra shrugged.

Catra crawled over to Adora before rolling onto her back and staring up at her as she ate. Adora tried to keep eating but feeling Catra’s eyes was making her nervous, and she hadn’t been *super* hungry to start off with.

“You done?” Catra asks, her eyes half-lidded.

“Yes,” Adora replies reluctantly.

Catra laughs while she bites her bottom lip. “And what if I decide I want *you* for dessert?”

Adora nervously clears her throat. “Didn’t you *just* ask me to have some class?”

“Well, *yeah,* ” Catra stands and puts her hands on Adora’s shoulders. “You’re a *princess* . I’m just some lowly street-urchin-” Catra hops into Adora’s lap, her face so close Adora can feel her breath. “I don’t bear *any* burden of *class.* ” Catra’s legs wrap around Adora’s waist.

Adora’s heart races as Catra bites her bottom lip again. Adora gently wraps her arms around Catra’s back. She’s trying not to make a fool of herself, but Catra’s keeping her at the perfect distance where she doesn’t know when or even *if* Catra’s going to kiss her. Her chin instinctively tilts up as Catra purrs, nestling her rear into Adora’s lap.

Eventually Catra relents, pressing her lips against Adora’s. This kiss feels so much *sweeter* than the one earlier. Maybe it’s just more practiced- but it’s probably also helped by the fact that neither of them are currently crying or on the very verge of *tears* .

Adora’s shocked by how *natural* it feels to kiss Catra. The only part of it that *maybe* feels odd is how each of them has an aversion to cradling or otherwise touching each-other’s heads or faces. It’ll probably take a while for that to feel anywhere near appropriate, especially for Catra after Prime.

When the kiss ends Adora feels- cut off. Like she’s not done, even though she knows that the kiss had lasted quite a while. Catra purrs louder as Adora’s face tries to connect with hers again. Catra leans in and kisses her forehead, her nose, her cheek, but right before she makes contact with Adora’s lips she backs away again.

“Please-” Adora whines.

Catra’s delighted giggles dance between Adora’s ears. “Please *what?* ”

"I need you to kiss me more…" Adora begins holding Catra by the shoulders, gently trying to pull her closer.

Catra gently obliges, kissing Adora deeper and using her tongue a bit more deftly and lovingly than last time. A little practice feels like it's already gone a long way- by the time the kiss breaks, this time it's for *air.*

"I love that look you're giving me~" Catra teases. "So desperate for my touch. It's kinda cute- and a little *pathetic~* "

As Adora catches her breath her feelings mix. Catra's adversarial nature hasn't gone away- she'd never *want* it to, but it's so *distracting.* She wants to kiss, not play out a *rivalry.*

Adora's eyes meet Catra's again, as her hands tighten on her shoulders. Catra's eyebrows raise in excitement. "Yeah~?" She questions, before Adora throws her onto the bed and pins her, still panting. Catra laughs, her hands finding Adora's hips and gently holding them.

Adora takes Catra's hands and roughly pins them to the bed; their fingers interlocked.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Didn't we already do this?"

Adora leans in and bites Catra's neck, inviting a scream and a hiss- quickly chased by purring as Adora begins to suck. She sucks as hard as she can- so hard that she feels the pressure on the inside of her mouth before she lets go at a whimpering Catra's behest.

"I- am *so* getting you back for that." Catra glares up at Adora, her solemn vow sworn.

Adora laughs as Catra bucks beneath her, knocking her off balance enough that they're rolling over each-other. It's a very nerve-wracking game to play- Adora trying to keep at least one hand on Catra's forehead as she brandishes her teeth closer and closer to any piece of Adora her jaw can fit around. Of course,

Adora's also getting scratched up, but Catra isn't even *meaning* to do *that.*

A knock at the door leads to Adora getting distracted enough that Catra's face slides free from her hand and latches onto her shoulder, growling and purring.

"***Ow!*** *You little brat-*" Adora tries to grab Catra's hair but it hasn't grown back enough to make for a good grip yet.

The knock repeats louder as Catra's grip tightens slightly, her growling getting louder due to how the intrusion is frustrating her.

"Yeah?" Adora calls to the door, while whispering to Catra, trying to negotiate a time-out.

"Are you two okay? We heard Catra scream." Bow's voice comes through the door.

"There was a mouse!" Catra's teeth break through Adora's skin as she grits her teeth.

Glimmer's voice calls in. "Just be careful, okay? No 'indoor sparring.' I don't want things getting broken."

"Well that'll be easy to avoid because we're not doing that, it was a mouse!" Catra bites deeper again, prompting an only slightly restrained yelp and a 'what's wrong with you?'

After a quiet moment, Catra finally releases and sits back, still straddling Adora. "You *really* can't act to save your life, can you?" Her teeth are lightly stained red.

"How the hell do you expect me to act when you're biting into my shoulder like I'm your first ration after getting ungrounded!?" Adora wipes the drool off of her shoulder- it's not *bleeding.* Not *really.* "And it was *your* little yell that got us caught, not *mine.* "

"You bit my neck without asking! I was *chipped* , remember? For a moment there, that wasn't scary in *any* of the ways I like!" Catra

huffs, but maintains a frustrated smile.

Realization dawns across Adora's face. "Oh my god- Catra, I'm so sorry, I-"

"Calm *down,* princess." She leans in and kisses Adora. Her lips taste faintly of blood. "It very quickly became scary in all my *favourite* ways."

Nevertheless, she sits back up and gently rubs her neck. She does need a moment just to breathe, and to get used to the ache. Her other hand grasps Adora's tightly.

"They *absolutely* thought we were having sex," Catra anxiously muses, looking to the door.

"To be fair, *I* wasn't sure if we were having sex or not and I've been here the whole time." Adora says, only half-joking.

Catra looks down at her fondly. "I've never made anything easy for you *before,* you really thought you'd have my pants off that fast?"

Adora blinks, still very red in the face. "I don't know, I'm still processing everything that's happened since the soup."

Catra suddenly puts her hands on Adora's shoulders and leans in, kissing her with a theatrical amount of angst and hesitation. *"Adora-"*

"Catra?" Adora asks a little too earnestly.

"I just- I don't think I'm ready to have a baby." Catra smiles.

It genuinely takes Adora a moment to think as strange maternal impulses flow through her body. Once the obvious dawns on her, she glares up at her girlfriend. "Yeah, how will we ever avoid *that* ."

Catra laughs, and then for a long time she just stares down at Adora with a suffocating *fondness* flowing from her eyes. A cloying sweetness so unlike the sugary pink sentiments that surround the two in Brightmoon. The adoration that paralyzes her is completely unique to Catra. It was as sweet as it was scary- the knowledge nobody else could make Adora feel this way, probably *ever.*

"I love you, Adora." Catra lays down on Adora, her ear pressed to her chest so that she can hear her heartbeat.

"I love you too, Catra. I love you a *lot.* "

Catra giggled. "Lucky me~"

Eventually the two prepared to settle into their bed- it had only sustained minimal damage, most of which being during their wrestling match. It was a lot earlier than the two usually want to sleep, but Catra was getting pouty any time Adora tried to get up, and Adora was getting pouty from lying on the floor.

As the two get dressed for bed, Catra makes a point of covering her chest with her arm, something that strikes Adora as notably unusual. Adora notes this as unusual because of the difficulty Adora has not staring.

"... Can you be a *little* more subtle, please?" Catra asks, while she wanders over to turn out the lights.

Adora nods, but fails to be more subtle.

Once the lights are out Adora lays back, and Catra crawls on top of her. Catra can't help but purr- in fact she's purring so loud it's making the skin on Adora's chest a bit numb. Catra mumbles an 'I love you' into Adora's chest, seemingly already about to pass out. Adora says it back, and begins to stare at the ceiling.

The ceiling was perfectly still. Catra was gently fidgeting and moving, trying to nestle into Adora just right. A loving warmth

filled the room- a sweet one that Adora couldn’t help but smile about.

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